

War Stock

In a memory of Sergeant Briggs and Blackhoof Witherspine

The enemy camp was still smouldering when Briggs led them through the broken gate. Enemy goblin soldiers dead lay where they had fallen. The supply tents had already been found by the men ahead of them, and the sounds of methodical looting drifted from that direction with the cheerful efficiency of soldiers who knew how little time they had.

Briggs moved through it all without hurrying, reading the layout the way he read everything — quietly, completely, filing things away.

Blackhoof followed and said nothing. He was learning, slowly, that silence was the correct language for the aftermath of battle. The first time he had tried to speak in the hour after fighting, Briggs had looked at him with an expression that needed no translation, and he had stopped.

It was Orehoof who spotted the enclosure first.

"Over there," he said, with the brightness of someone who had not yet learned to moderate his enthusiasm. "War hogs."

The enclosure was set at the camp's eastern edge, built solid — heavy posts, doubled rope, the kind of construction that suggested the animals inside were worth keeping secure. There were perhaps thirty of them. Large, dark-bristled, scarred along their flanks in the particular way of animals that had been trained for combat rather than slaughter. They moved in the enclosed space with the restless energy of creatures that had heard the battle and smelled the blood and were still waiting to understand what it meant for them.

Blackhoof stood at the fence and watched them.

Around him, the business of the captured camp continued. A group of goblins from the third unit had already moved to the enclosure's far side and were in conversation with what appeared to be the enemy's remaining stock-keeper — a small, resigned-looking goblin who had clearly decided that cooperation was preferable to the alternative. He was pointing at various animals and nodding, and Briggs's goblins were nodding back with the satisfied expressions of men solving a practical problem.

"Good meat on those," one of them said, to no one in particular.

"Shame about the saddles," said another. "Fitted for their backs, not our horses. Can't use them."

"Can't ride them either. No use for us." A third one laughed — a flat, practical sound.

Blackhoof's hands tightened on the fence post.

"They're war animals," he said. His voice came out more level than he expected. "Trained. They took years to—"

The goblin who had spoken turned and looked at him with the particular expression of someone registering an unexpected noise from an unexpected source. Not hostility. Not even contempt, exactly. Something more complete than contempt — the look of a man who has been addressed by something he had not previously considered capable of address.

"You need something, centaur?"

The word landed the way it was meant to. Not as a name. As a category.

Before Blackhoof could take some air to his lungs, a hand closed briefly on his arm — small, firm, positioned with the precision of someone who knew exactly where to apply pressure and for how long.



"Walk with me," Briggs said quietly.

It was not a request. But it was not hard, either — there was something in the tone, some quality below the flatness, that Blackhoof filed away without quite understanding it.

He walked.

Behind them, the practical conversation continued, and the stock-keeper began opening the gate to the enclosure, and Orehoof drifted toward the activity with the easy curiosity of someone who had found the afternoon's entertainment.

Briggs said nothing until they were out of earshot.

Then he said: "Not here."

"They were talking about—"

"I know what they were talking about." He didn't slow his pace. "Not here."

They ate that evening at the edge of the camp's firelight — Briggs, Blackhoof, and the particular silence that had settled between them since the enclosure. The meat turned on spits across the fire. Blackhoof ate because not eating would have meant something he wasn't ready to declare, and the food was good, and he hated a little how it was good.

Orehoof sat across the fire, working through his portion with uncomplicated satisfaction.

Blackhoof watched the flames for a while.

"We're stock," he said finally. Not loud. Not angry. Just a fact he was setting down to look at. Briggs said nothing.

"That's what they said. Riding stock." He turned the word over. "That's what we are to them. Items in a supply ledger." He paused. "They put the same thought into us as into those hogs. Train them, feed them, ride them, and if the situation changes—" He stopped.

The fire crackled. Briggs drank from his flask and looked at the middle distance with the expression he used for things he had decided not to engage with.

"Was any of it real?" Blackhoof asked. "The training. The— they told us we'd be the finest cavalry. That it was an honour. That in a hundred years there'd be—" He stopped again, because the words sounded different out loud than they had in his head for the past months. Smaller. "They put those thoughts in us so we'd fight better. Didn't they."

Briggs was quiet for long enough that Blackhoof began to think there would be no answer at all.

"A sword doesn't fight better if you tell it stories," Briggs said eventually. "A soldier does." He took another pull from the flask. "Make of that what you will."

"That's not an answer."

"No."

"Briggs—"

"What do you want me to tell you?" His voice was flat, not unkind, carrying the weight of a man who had arrived at this particular crossroads before and knew all the roads leading away from it. "That it isn't true? That you're different? That the goblin army has your best interests at heart?" He set the flask down. "You're a good soldier. You're quick and you think under pressure and you don't panic, which is rarer than it sounds. Your legs are strong and hands fast. That's real. What you do in the line is real." A pause. "Whether anyone is keeping score is a separate question."

"And if we'd lost today," Blackhoof said. "The hogs. We..."

The silence that followed was answer enough.

"Yes," Briggs said, because leaving it unspoken would have been its own kind of lie. "Possibly. War is a practical business."

Orehoof tore another piece of meat from the bone across the fire, cheerful and oblivious, and the fire between them threw its light and its shadows in equal measure, and Blackhoof sat with the wreckage of something he hadn't quite known he was carrying until it was gone.

He had been so certain, for so long, that there was something waiting for him. A shape his life was moving toward — something earned in battle, recognised in the eyes of men who

mattered, rendered eventually in stone or song. Now he looked at it clearly for the first time and saw it for what it was.

Something put there to make him useful.

He looked at Briggs — at the side of his face in the firelight, unreadable still, giving nothing away. There was something Blackhoof wanted to say that he didn't have words for yet. Something about the difference between being useful and being seen. Something about the specific loneliness of sitting next to the one person whose opinion he had come to care about and not knowing whether that caring went in any direction at all.

He didn't say it.

Briggs felt the look without turning to meet it. He felt it the way you felt things you had trained yourself not to react to — precisely, and with the full knowledge of what ignoring it cost.

No, he thought. The word he had been saying to himself since the first morning, since the parade ground, since the die had rolled three and an eager young centaur had stepped forward with his armour gleaming and his whole future written on his face. No. You know how it ends. You have always known how it ends.

The fire burned on, indifferent, sending its light up into the dark and its shadows dancing across the tents of sleeping men, and the two of them sat inside that circle of warmth and said nothing more, and the silence that settled between them was not comfortable and not empty.

It was the silence of two creatures sitting on opposite sides of a threshold, one desperate to cross the distance between them and lacking only the courage to move, the other equally desperate to keep it — who would have widened it with both hands, if he could have done it without being seen.

The flames leaned in the night wind, steadied, leaned again.

Neither of them moved.